

Places of the Imagination

Media, Tourism, Culture

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Chapter 8

Conclusion: The Magic of Imagining

In the summer of 2010, three years after the start of this research project, I found myself once more in Oxford. The reason for my presence there was the new Harry Potter tour: a walking tour through the centre of Oxford to the locations that had been used for the books and films about this apprentice wizard. The Harry Potter tour was not the only media-related attraction in Oxford; tourists could now choose between an Alice in Wonderland tour, a Literary tour, a Tolkien tour or an Oxford Film Sites tour.

Despite the increase in competition from other media tours, the Inspector Morse Tour also seemed to be enjoying enduring popularity. Every day, scores of Morse fans were still wandering past the pubs, houses and crime scenes which were connected with the eponymous television detective and his successor Lewis. Once again the same serene silence set in at the moment that the party arrived at the lawn of Exeter College.

That tourists would stand in awed silence at the spot where a much-loved fictional personality collapsed with a heart attack, had at first astonished me. Now, at the end of the research project, astonishment has given way to recognition. The world seems to be full of comparable 'magic' places, which perhaps to the outsider mean nothing, but which for the initiated have a special meaning and have a connection with particular stories, which are very close to their hearts. These are the ubiquitous *lieux d'imagination* (places of the imagination): symbolic-material references to a world of the imagination.

Imagination and Religion

Earlier studies have alluded to the supposedly religious character of this form of tourism. The analogy between media tours and religious pilgrimages is indeed striking: just as pilgrims travel to places which have a sacred meaning for them – normally because a miracle has occurred there or it is the resting place for the tangible remains of some holy person – so fans make their journeys to the locations of film or television recordings, in the hope of picking up the trail of their much-loved characters. The religious miracles are replaced by marvellous stories of superheroes, vampire hunters and detectives but the essence remains the same: both cases concern stories about charismatic characters who are embroiled in a struggle against Evil. And somewhere in the world, lie the relics – physical remains – which commemorate this struggle, whether they take the form of a lawn (Morse), a tomb (Dracula) or, in the case of Bond, a blood-



Figure 8.1 The bloodied shirt of James Bond, worn by Daniel Craig during the filming of *Casino Royale*

Source: Danjaq, LLC United Artists Corp, Columbia Pictures.

stained shirt, as depicted in Figure 8.1. This shirt, worn by Daniel Craig during the filming of *Casino Royale*, was displayed in April 2008 at the Imperial War Museum in London as part the exhibition on James Bond and Ian Fleming: *For Your Eyes Only*.

However, it would be a step too far to talk of a complete similarity between religious pilgrimages and the phenomenon of media tourism. Equating religion to

fiction does not do justice to the essential difference between the two phenomena that those involved experience. Many of the people I spoke to in the interviews felt themselves to be strongly involved in the stories,¹ but their relationship with them was ultimately characterized by a suspension of disbelief. They surrendered themselves willingly to the power of their imagination, but this abandonment at all times played itself out within clear boundaries. What above all made media tourism attractive for them was precisely the underlying contrast between imagination and reality – the symbolic crossing of the border between two qualities. It can be properly assumed that the attitude of religious pilgrims is fundamentally different: most of them operate under the assumption of an underlying Truth, which they believe in.

Besides this is the question of whether pilgrimages and media tourism ultimately fulfill a comparable function. From a historical perspective, religious pilgrimages have always had differing goals: people went out of religious conviction, for the companionship or for recreation or for penance (in the past, people convicted of crimes could, in some cases, mitigate their sentence if they went on a pilgrimage). Today pilgrimages still fulfill various functions, but what has become increasingly important is the supposed healing power of pilgrimages. Anyone who has visited the cave at Lourdes can vouch for this: the cave is visited by a constant stream of invalids and the elderly, walking on crutches or sitting in wheelchairs, and even patients lying in hospital beds are not an infrequent sight. In media tourism elements of healing are scarce. As became apparent in the analysis of Bond tourism earlier in this book, Bond locations for some fans serve as a symbolic-material source of masculinity, where they can immerse themselves in the ‘mediated masculinity’ of Bond. But strictly speaking this seems to appeal not so much to a desire to be healed but to a longing for *male rejuvenation*.

To resume, in my view the comparison between religion and media tourism is somewhat unfortunate, because it puts two things on a par with each other, which are fundamentally different. In a certain sense the comparison itself is misleading: it makes the unknown (media tourism) *apparently familiar* by putting it together with the known (the pilgrimage).

That said, there is unmistakable recognition of a definite structural analogy between media tourism and the pilgrimage. Both phenomena clearly have a number of common characteristics. In my view, however, this cannot be explained by seeing the one as a contemporary variant of the other, but by interpreting both phenomena as the externalization of an underlying need. What people in both cases strive for is to *make tangible* that which is not tangible in the first place. By coupling imagination or religion (both being complex imaginary systems) to specific locations and material objects, something that is fundamentally

1 For some tourists, media tours serve only as a practical stepping-stone – a recognizable starting point for getting to know a new city or region. However this clearly applies only to a minority; the majority of tourists who were interviewed for this project, spoke of having a strong bond with the films, books or television series concerned.

immaterial can be pinned down, appropriated and consumed. In this sense, eating a Wallander cake is comparable to receiving the consecrated host: people give form to an abstract idea (to paraphrase Plato), in order subsequently to take it literally inside themselves. This is, as it were, a magical act, centred around the fundamental boundary between the bodily and the spiritual. By making the spiritual material and consuming it, so the belief goes, part of its power can be appropriated.

This book was directed specifically at media tourism: the act of visiting locations which are connected with popular media narratives. However, the urge to make something tangible out of what is intangible seems to be somewhat more widespread in contemporary popular culture. Think, for example, of the graves of media celebrities, which can exert an enormous power of attraction on fans. Memorable examples of this are the grave of Jim Morrison in Père-Lachaise or the tomb of Elvis Presley in Graceland. This attracts more than half a million visitors a year and was even chosen a few years ago as a 'national landmark'. Celebrities of this stature have been all but inaccessible during their lifetimes, but now fans can stand just six feet from the remains of their hero. Another example is the active trade in the clothing, utensils and garbage of celebrities on websites like Ebay.com (Britney Spears' spat out chewing gum fetches prices of up to \$14,000). In this sense, there seems to be a commonly felt need for *proximity*: people want to be literally close to the stars and the stories which they have grown up with. It could be suggested that this need for proximity implicitly betrays a feeling of *distance* – a yawning chasm between what is experienced as the world in the media and the world outside of it. To the extent that the influence of the media on our world becomes stronger, it seems that non-mediated experiences acquire a more and more unique character.

But with these general conclusions we are getting ahead of ourselves. First it is our task to lay out the results of this research. What was researched in this book is how making the intangible tangible is formalized in the actual practice of media tourism. Three examples were investigated: television detective tours; James Bond trips and Dracula tours. On the basis of fieldwork in, among other places Amsterdam, Oxford, Ystad, Jamaica, London, Schilthorn, Thailand, Whitby and Transylvania, it can now be concluded that the act of making tangible a piece of the imagination takes, in practice, two forms. One can discern a rational mode and an emotional-intuitive mode.

Rational Mode

The first mode concerns a rational search for the 'truth' behind a story. Many media tourists assert that they spend a considerable amount of time and attention in tracing the locations where a film, television series or novel has been played out, in order subsequently to make a detailed comparison in situ between the diegetic space of the stories and the physical-material space which they encounter at these locations. Concrete aspects are compared such as journey distances, the number of

steps in a staircase, the size and dimensions of a building, the kinds of nature, the direction and flow of the traffic.

Although the rational mode recurs in all three cases, it comes to the fore particularly for fans of Bond and fans of the television detectives *Inspector Morse*, *Baantjer* and *Wallander*. Many Bond fans, for example, seem to make stills of important 'on location' scenes before they set off, so that they can subsequently take their own photograph from the same perspective, with the ultimate goal of investigating in detail and revealing the difference between 'reel' and 'real'. The fans of *Baantjer* exhibit similar behaviour. The author Appie Baantjer (who passed away in 2010), regularly received letters from readers, in which they illustrated in a friendly but resolute way the 'impossibility' of certain passages – in most cases related to the routes taken by detective De Cock.

What these fans are actually doing is internalizing and reliving the investigative activities of the films, series and books concerned. Just like their beloved detectives or superspies, these fans embark on an investigation in search of the truth, rooting around from clue to clue, and fussing over details in order to establish a difference between facts and false trails. The essence for them lies not so much in what they find as in the process of discovery. In other words, this involves a rational structure of detection and investigation, in which reality and imagination are brought face to face.

As comprehensively dealt with in Chapter 2, question marks can be placed against such a rigid contrast between reality and imagination. In practice, reality and imagination often complement each other quite appropriately. On the one hand, imagination is to a great extent based on the sensory experience of our physical surroundings; it is the creative reworking of what we are already familiar with. On the other hand, it is not possible to acquire an unequivocal picture of reality without using one's imagination to some degree. It is the power of the imagination which musters all our sensory stimuli together to the point where we experience 'the' reality. The imagination shuttles as it were, between idealistic concepts and sensory experience. In this sense, reality and imagination are not divorced from each other but interwoven and mutually dependent.

This, however, as was set out in the chapter concerned, is not to deny the fact that many people really have the need for a clear and fundamental separation between both of these qualities. And that is precisely what occurs in what we have called the 'rational mode'. By reflecting the world of the imagination in the physical characteristics at a location, sometimes in an almost geometric manner, the symbolic distinction between reality and imagination acquires a tangible and seemingly 'natural' character.

Emotional-intuitive Mode

The second mode concerns a more emotional, intuitive search for *bodily proximity*. Many of the media tourists interviewed derive no pleasure from a rational comparison between reality and imagination, but want to become themselves

part of the world of the imagination and to experience this 'alternative' world themselves. For this reason the detective fans wander through the streets of Oxford, Amsterdam and Ystad, past the houses and crime scenes of their beloved detective. They want to visit the bars where the detectives always hang out, so that they can sit on their stools and drink their drinks, be they cognac (Baantjer), a pint of beer (Morse) or a cup of coffee (Wallander). These fans want to get the feeling that their beloved detective could at any moment come walking round the corner, or just up the road – look, there! – might step out of the police station.

In a similar way, Dracula fans undertake the same journey as Jonathan Harker did around 100 years before. They stay in the same hotels and enjoy the same meals as Harker – 'robber steak' – served with a glass of blood wine. During the interviews Dracula fans tell of how exciting they find it to be in the land of Count Dracula themselves. They speak of the power of the attraction which the Count exerts on them and the erotic tension which his threatening presence generates – like a subliminal death wish. The story of Dracula is a story of sex, death and repressed desire – carnality steams from its pages. Of course, this has an influence on the make-up of the Dracula Tour. During the seven-day journey, locations from Dracula are combined with important places from the life of Vlad Dracula (a blood-thirsty, fifteenth-century prince, who according to some authors was the inspiration for the Dracula character) and other 'dark' locations such as torture chambers, prisons and graveyards. This immersion in stories about death and suffering make the Dracula Tour seem more like a trip into the underworld, in which the tourist, like a latter day Orpheus, becomes confronted with the vulnerability of the human body.

However, ultimately there are limits to the need for bodily proximity. In the case of the Dracula Tour there is certainly a sense of a voyage into the underworld, but at the same time, the journey takes place within the comfortable context of the 'tourist bubble'. The tourists experience a sense of Otherness, but always from a position of safety and cleanliness. Symptomatic of this are the plastic gloves, which are handed out to participants in the Baantjer Tour, before they take the fingerprints of a hired-in homeless person. Ultimately it is this thin plastic layer that keeps both worlds apart.

Even Bond fans, who generally take pride in the rational nature of their fascination (they prefer to talk about 'investigating the actuality' and 'finding out about the technical process of filming'), are sometimes in the grip of their own imaginations. Once on the spot, it overcomes almost every Bond fan: suddenly he finds himself standing with his legs slightly apart and his right hand in the air as if he were holding a gun. These Bond fans too talk about being 'engrossed' in the world of Bond: about how their physical presence at the correct locations, perhaps combined with adopting a certain pose or sometimes acting out complete scenes, induces in them the feeling that they have themselves become a part of a Bond adventure. They also tell of how it is to be caught up in the excitement and the 'thrill', which is so characteristic of the life of their beloved superspy.

Of course, the rational mode and the emotional-intuitive mode are not entirely separate from one another. It is after all possible to cross the line between imagination and reality after this symbolic boundary has been defined and marked out. In this sense, the rational mode is a logical instigator of the emotional-intuitive mode. Disenchantment is followed by re-enchantment. Sometimes each mode follows the other in the experience of an independent traveller. In other situations there is a larger travelling group, in which the internal group dynamic leads to a division of modes among the various group members. Regardless of comparable practical variations, in both cases a similar pattern emerges, and we should be able to identify an underlying dynamic of the imagination.

The Circuit of the Imagination

The concept of 'imagination' has been regarded with suspicion for a long time in Western thinking. Early Christians even thought that the imagination constituted a real danger, which lay at the heart of one of the worst sins – adultery. In the ages of Reason and Enlightenment, movements which exerted a dominant influence on Western philosophy, imagination was interpreted as the opposite of reason. It was considered a human weakness, an obstacle in mankind's progress towards self-fulfillment. Imagination was directly compared to loss of control (Huppau and Wolf 2009).

Various thinkers have in later times tried to reassess the idea of imagination. Most notable among these is the Romantic school of the late eighteenth century, for whom the power of the imagination was a requirement for creativity and innovation. These thinkers ultimately acknowledged the same Kantian dichotomy between imagination and reason, but drew different conclusions as to their value; for them rationalism meant a simplification of human thinking while the creative power of the imagination on the other hand constituted the noblest good.

Notwithstanding similar efforts, the concept of 'imagination' still suffers a perverse reputation in the scientific world. It is at best regarded as a counterpart to reason and at worst as the domain of romantic, unscientific drivel. It still plays a minimal role even in the disciplines of media studies and cultural studies. And that is a shame, because it is in just this sort of discipline that it has an important contribution to make. Where accepted terms like 'representation' and 'text' place the emphasis on *conveyors of meaning* the concept of the imagination shifts the attention onto the underlying process of *interpretation of meaning*. Imagination offers the possibility to build a bridge between research domains which as a rule are studied separately from one another: the fields of production and consumption, for example; or the processes of individual interpretation of meaning and collective interpretation; or representations in media on the one hand and personal ideas and actions on the other.

This potential has not remained unnoticed. Recently various authors have argued the case for a re-evaluation and instrumentalization of the concept of

imagination within the fields of media studies (Crouch, Jackson and Thompson 2005) and cultural philosophy (Huppauw and Wolf 2009). This book marches in step with these recent initiatives. In previous chapters, first a theory about imagination was set out, after which in subsequent chapters, the theory was adapted to the phenomenon of media tourism. The basis for this was the notion that imagination and reality are intrinsically connected with each other: things that are imagined emanate from sensory experience and conversely the power of the imagination is needed to channel the profusion of sensory stimuli into a clear notion of 'the' reality. Simultaneously, many people rightly feel the need to make a clear separation between these two concepts; imagination and reality are, as a rule, experienced as two distinct worlds. This paradoxical relationship leads, so it is supposed, to a circular process – the circuit of the imagination. In the case of media tourism, this can be split into four consecutive phases:

1. Physical places inspire artists;
2. Artists construct places that they have imagined;
3. Imagined places are appropriated by fans; and
4. Fans go in search of physical references to imagined places (see Figure 2.1 on page 17).

Our empirical research into the television detectives, James Bond and Dracula has given further substance to this theory and has generated a number of surprising results. For example, as became clear in the preceding chapters, stories do not just come out of the blue. The authors and filmmakers who were researched derived their inspiration to no small degree from their experience and knowledge of existing places. In the case of the detective tours, it seemed that all three original authors had personal experience of the locations in which their detectives were situated: Henning Mankell (author of *Wallander*) lived for some time on a farm just outside Ystad; Colin Dexter (author of *Morse*) still lives in Oxford and Appie Baantjer (author of *Inspector De Cock*, filmed under the title of *Baantjer*) worked for a long time in Amsterdam. Visiting the locations formed an important part of the writing process. Colin Dexter, for example, described during his interview how, before writing a Morse novel, he first did some research into the location: he wandered through the streets that he would later describe and talked to local residents on the street and in the pubs in order to get a taste of the *couleur locale*. In Appie Baantjer's case, one can even point to years of personal experience as a police detective in the Red Light District; an experience which, in his own words lent considerable substance to the stories about Inspector De Cock.

Personal experience, however, is not actually necessary. Bram Stoker's description of Transylvania is very detailed and paints a vivid picture; thousands of people have been inspired by his words to relive the journey of Jonathan Harker. But strikingly enough, Stoker himself never actually set foot in Romania; he based his description entirely on literary travel stories and existing descriptions that he dug up in the National Library in London.

Nevertheless, we can see also from the case of *Dracula* how many stories are located somewhere. We may not be conscious of it, but almost every popular story – be it in the form of a novel, a film or a television series – is played out in a recognizable environment, to which can be ascribed a location. Stories become, so to speak, grafted onto existing landscapes (or cityscapes), a process through which symbols of local identity become exhibited and reproduced. Or, to reverse the reasoning, these stories contribute something to the *tourist gaze* of Oxford, Amsterdam, Ystad or Transylvania. They ‘inject’ the landscape with narrative meaning, giving it a meaning which delves below the surface of the image. Perhaps there are two genres which regularly deviate from this rule: *science fiction* and *fantasy*. It may, however, be regarded as typical that this is often the type of story in which undue attention is paid to the description of the ‘fictitious’ geographical environment (a striking example being the geofiction of *The Lord of the Rings*).

What the fieldwork also brought to the attention is how strongly making acquaintance with the physical landscape is directed by themes and viewpoints from the world of the imagination. For example, we found that the set-up and structure of the television detective tours owes a large debt to the characteristics of the content of the relevant television series. As far as narrative development is concerned, the tours offer an equivalent ‘montage’ of different locations, spread over the city and varied with short walks. At the centre lies the perspective of the detective, which, just as in the series, promises access to the darkest secrets of the local community. The tourist goes literally *backstage*, and is promised an apparently legitimate glimpse at the life and wounded body of another. Behold the universal attraction of crime stories and the underlying voyeuristic desire. With the detective as a surrogate, people can creep literally and figuratively under the skin of an unknown person.

In a similar sort of way, Bond tourism seems to be based on a synergy between espionage and tourism. Bond fans follow in the footsteps of their beloved spy, as they tell us in the interviews, and get access to locations from the novels and films, where denial of access seems to serve more as a recommendation than as a deterrent. The participants are, like Bond, predominantly white men in middle age, who enter and traverse the exotic landscape of the Other. These Bond tourists are different from ‘normal’ tourists because they have a mission: localizing, pinpointing and consuming the world of Fleming’s imagination. The term ‘Fleming effect’ has in the past been used for Ian Fleming’s trademark of ending every chapter with a *cliffhanger*. This effect can also be regarded as the desired state for any Bond tourist: to have the feeling of being absorbed into the adventurous *rush* of Bond – of being carried round in the maelstrom of his life.

Finally, what was also noticeable during the research was the way in which the physical reality was adapted to the imagined reality. In some cases small adaptations were made to street furniture. For example, various information boards were placed in the streets of Ystad, with which the association with *Wallander’s* Ystad was physically acknowledged. In other cases names were changed. In Oxford a pub – as a result, among other factors, of pressure from

competing initiatives – was renamed ‘the’ Inspector Morse Pub. In Amsterdam a café in the Jordaan neighbourhood that had partly been the model for the local pub of Inspector De Cock was rechristened ‘*Smalle Lowietje*’, the name of the café in the series. In the mountains of Transylvania, an entire neogothic castle hotel, The Dracula Castle Hotel, was built more or less at the location where Bram Stoker’s story was originally set.

Similar commercial initiatives notwithstanding, the municipalities of Amsterdam, Transylvania and Ystad also exhibited a certain reserve with respect to media tourism – certainly whenever the theme of the media product concerned did not coincide with the image desired by the local council or tourist office. Other organizations also sometimes had their doubts. At first police officers in Ystad were to say the least suspicious when asked on the street by tourists for a photograph or for information about *Wallander*. However, with the help of an enthusiastic press officer, attitudes were reversed and stories about *Wallander* became a common point of reference among police officers, for example in the use of nicknames for colleagues and in describing certain cases as being ‘typically Wallander’. In this case, the imagination, itself a product of reality, was developed into an independent point of reference and frame of interpretation for one’s own daily life.

Imagination and Memory

One last question remains, concerning the relationship between imagination and memory. As described in the previous chapter, the work of the French historian, Pierre Nora, has made an important contribution to this research. Nora’s investigation into the working of the collective memory lay at the heart of the concept of places of the imagination, as developed in this book. But where Pierre Nora focused on collective memory, the focus of this book shifts to the collective imagination. How has this shift ultimately been manifested in practice?

What can first of all be concluded from the research is that *memoria* plays a significant role in the phenomenon of media tourism: memories of the past and the act of remembering itself crop up repeatedly in the cases researched and recur on different levels.

Firstly, many media tourists commemorate in situ the production process that lies at the heart of the imagined world. For example, Bond fans speak most respectfully of the EON team who produced the James Bond movies and they regard visiting the film locations as a mark of respect to the filmmakers. Once there, they try to get a clear picture of precisely how the films were recorded and what sort of physical problems or obstacles the film crew were confronted with. Although this aspect of things plays a lesser role with the other two parties researched, participants in the television detective tours and the Dracula Tour are regularly given details of the production process – normally in the form of

‘amusing’ anecdotes about the behaviour of the actors off stage or snippets of information about the camera techniques used.

Secondly, for many participants visiting places of the imagination sets in motion a process of reminiscence. By being on the spot themselves and calling to mind certain features of the story or even imitating them, not only do they make the story and the production process come to life, but they also trigger associated memories. What many media tourists for example speak about is the memory of making their first acquaintance with the story. Dracula fans think with pleasure back to the first time they read Stoker’s novel or watched one of the film versions. The same goes for Bond fans. Most of them find all 22 films interesting but have a special connection with the Bond film that they saw for the first time in the cinema. They all speak lovingly of a recurring memory: how they as youngsters first entered the confined space of the cinema, mostly accompanied by their father to lose themselves for an hour and a half in the world of James Bond. These memories of their youth and of their father in their turn summon more general memories about this period of their lives. By visiting Bond locations and comparing the current landscape with what it looked like in the film, the Bond fans, as described in an earlier chapter, see what has been changed over the years – not only in themselves and in Bond, but also in the wider cultural landscape of which they both form a part.

Finally the dividing line between imagination and memory is often difficult to draw. The discussion about the historical background of Dracula is typical of this. According to research from the 1970s, the character Dracula can be traced back directly to the historical figure Vlad Tepes. Although strong doubts about this association have arisen among later literary historians, many tourists eagerly swallow it up. For them the historical authenticity of Vlad Tepes heightens the appeal of Dracula and vice versa: Vlad Tepes has been made interesting because of his association with Count Dracula. This two-way relationship also crops up during the Dracula Tour, in which visiting Dracula locations is combined with visiting the locations which have something to do with the life or death of Vlad Tepes. During the tour, it is true, the Romanian guides make considerable efforts to emphasize the separation of the fictitious and the historical, but in the experience of the tourists, the stories of blood-drinking vampires, burning people and impaling political opponents flow together into a single universe: the dark *place-myth* of Transylvania. We can identify a comparable process in the Baantjer Tour, in which stories about detective De Cock are freely intermingled with information about historical crimes that really took place, a combination which has resulted in the Red Light District in Amsterdam acquiring an ambiguous sort of crime folklore.

To resume, memory seems to play an important part in the way in which places of the imagination are experienced. In other words, one can identify a certain reciprocity between memory and imagination. Places like Transylvania and the Red Light District in Amsterdam derive their identity from a complex combination of memories and imagined events, from a system of stories in which events, whether fictitious or not, are placed side by side. These places are ‘authentic’ because they

provide the decor for the stories – historical and fictional. Simultaneously, the stories are experienced as ‘real’ because they are put into place.

The concept of places of the imagination is – even more so than its forerunner *lieux de mémoire* – a good tool for charting this dynamic process. Where Nora took the historical authenticity of a location as his starting point, this book describes the reverse process: how people, starting with their imagination, go in search of physical, material references. They use the world to give shape to their ideas – in order literally to give a place to their fantasies, dreams and feelings of fear as well as solidarity. These ideas can have ties to the past. Seen from this perspective, memory is no more or less than the imagination of the past. Equally, there can also be ideas or stories about the present and the future. Even utopias and dystopias cry out for a *locus*.

Without imagination there remains little of the world as we know it. However, imagination alone is not enough. If we want to form a picture of our own past, present and future – our experience of being in the world – then our imaginations have to take on also a tangible form. It is precisely in this twilight zone between a realized imagination and an imagined reality that media tourists hope to find their answers.

Chapter 5

Media Pilgrimages into the World of James Bond

In the Indian Ocean off the coast of southern Thailand lies an island that was originally known as Ko Tapu. For generations, the people of this island supported themselves by fishing, growing rice and tapping rubber. But in the middle of the 1970s, this way of life changed drastically. EON Productions – the production company responsible for the James Bond franchise – had seen the potential of the picturesque island as a location for *The Man with the Golden Gun* (1974). When this film, which was popular around the world, appeared, Ko Tapu became internationally famous almost overnight. It was particularly the shootout between James Bond and Scaramanga that nestled the island in the popular imagination (see Figure 5.1). Within a few years, Ko Tapu had become one of the top tourist attractions in Thailand, complete with James Bond tours, teeshirts and assorted souvenirs. ‘James Bond Island’, as it is now known, attracts over 1,000 visitors a day.



Figure 5.1 Scene from *The Man with the Golden Gun*, shot on Ko Tapu, now often known as ‘James Bond Island’

Source: Film still from *The Man With the Golden Gun* (1974), Eon Productions.

Chapter 2

Places of the Imagination

In this chapter, the foundations for a new theoretical perspective on media tourism shall be established. This perspective will be based on a combination of the work of the French historian Pierre Nora and the American anthropologist John Caughey. Central to this theme will be the introduction of a new concept: *lieux d'imagination*.

In Memoria

In the mid-1980s, Pierre Nora introduced the concept *lieux de mémoire*. According to Nora, modern, Western society was characterized by an obsession with the past. With the loosening of traditional social bonds, individuals and social groups were desperately in search of the roots of a shared identity. This had brought about a rich culture of memorialization, in Nora's interpretation. *Lieux de mémoire* had an important role in this, as places which can function as symbolic moorings in a turbulent world. These were generally physical places, such as memorials, monuments, or specific locations. In this way, Nora applied the term to the battlefields of Verdun, which had acquired an important, almost mythical status after the First World War, as a place to remember and memorialize the war. In addition, Nora applied the term *lieux de mémoire* to metaphorical places, like certain songs or celebrations (Nora 1984–1992).

Nora's ideas about the modern culture of memorialization have provided the foundation for a thorough and currently well-known series of studies of *lieux de mémoire* in France. Beside this, his work has been followed in other countries, among them Germany (Francois and Schulze 2001) and the Netherlands (De Boer and Frijhoff 1993; Wesseling 2005). What makes his approach so appealing is, in the first place, that he emphasized the constructed nature of memory. By showing how social institutions both consciously and subconsciously influence the way a society recollects its past and gives form to it, Nora broke with the neo-Durkheimian tradition, which interprets collective memory as an organic system (Legg 2005). He thus joined a new movement in the field of historic sciences, which among other things found expression in the study of 'invented traditions' (Hobsbawm and Ranger 1983). Secondly, Nora had a sharp eye for humankind's 'topophilic' nature. He pointed out the general need to identify certain places as holy, and to use these places as physical points of reference for a phenomenon

whose essence is non-physical. Apparently people need physical objects and places to give form to their memory, Nora proposed, as a way of ‘congealing’ time (cf. Bruno 2003).

Nora is usually considered a deconstructivist, since he did not investigate the historical event *an sich*, but the way in which the memory of this historical event took shape later. Though he did also consider non-physical locations, the emphasis for him lay in concrete, determinable places, where certain historical events had taken place in the past. In this sense, Nora did not take deconstructionism to its logical extreme; the historical authenticity of an actual location remained the point of departure.

The question remains whether the historical authenticity of a certain location is a necessary ingredient for the processes that Nora was investigating. Locations can serve equally well as the setting for a memorialization of something that never took place. This is certainly the case, for example, with instances of media tourism, which are mainly based on memorializing and reliving a *fictional* event. As a result it would appear justified, in cases such as these, to take the process of memorializing itself, and the resultant need for locations, as our starting point, rather than the actual historical location. Using this inverted logic, every possible location could, in principle, be suitable to memorialize and commodify an event, whether actual or fictional. Of course, in practice certain locations will definitely be more ‘authentic’ than others, though in this sense of the word, authenticity is something subjectively assigned to the place by individuals or groups, among them, for example, historians. The historical record definitely no longer has the monopoly on authentic place; geographical realism in fiction can also grant authenticity to a certain location.

In an attempt to make this alternative approach more concrete, in this chapter I shall introduce a new concept. *Lieux d’imagination* (‘places of the imagination’) are material reference points like objects or places, which for certain groups within society serve as material-symbolic references to a common imaginary world.¹ Imagination for this purpose can be defined as a mental conception of an object, person or event that at a certain time and in a certain place is not actually present. Memory in this context is nothing more, or less, than the imagination of an event from the past. Imagination can make reference to the past, but not necessarily so. It is also possible to imagine an event taking place elsewhere but in the same time period. Imagination of future events is also not beyond the realm of possibility. How many locations have been imagined before they became reality? Or as Edmundo O’Gorman put it: ‘America was invented before it was discovered’ (O’Gorman 1961). By shifting the emphasis from memory to imagination, the constructed and interrelated character of both phenomena can be further examined.

1 For sake of clarity, the English term ‘places of the imagination’ will be used in the remaining part of this book.

Appearance and Reality

This conceptual adjustment does raise some questions. First, there is the important question of a phenomenological explanation. Why do people need physical points of reference for their imagination? Nora maintained that this need is the result of an obsession with the past. But this does not always appear to be the case, for the simple reason that the concept 'places of the imagination' does not *per se* refer to the past. An alternative explanation can be found in the work of the cultural anthropologist John Caughey.

According to Caughey (1984), people live in two distinct worlds. On the one hand, they find themselves in the 'real' world, an empirically measurable reality, defined by time and place. On the other hand, there is a world of imagination, an interconnected complex of fantasies, daydreams and stories. Though these worlds are usually separated from each other, says Caughey, there are moments when both coincide temporarily. Such moments are meaningful, because they bring two elements together: the quotidian becomes unusual, while at the same time the strange and unknown is made usual (Caughey 1984).

Caughey's theory fits in a long, though admittedly rather subordinate, tradition in philosophy, which emphasizes the importance of *place* in the development of imagination. As Jeff Malpas argues in *Place and Experience* (1999), people's imagination is inextricably connected to their concrete, sensory experience of place. Even the wildest fantasies spring from something recognizable, for the simple reason that there would be no way to picture them otherwise. And not only do thoughts, fantasies and concepts spring from physical experiences, but, according to Malpas, they constantly seek confirmation from those physical experiences, mirroring it (Malpas 1999). The converse is also true. As the philosopher Immanuel Kant hypothesized two centuries earlier, it is impossible to conceive of a coherent picture of 'the' actuality or 'the' reality, without in some way making use of your imagination (Huppau and Wolf 2009: 2).

One of the problems with Caughey's theory, though, is that it's based on a binary opposition between an 'imagined' and a 'real' world. This imagination/reality dichotomy has been problematized in recent film theory (Creswell and Dixon 2002; Lukinbeal 2004; Aitken and Dixon 2006; Hanna 2000). As stated by Stuart Aitken and Deborah Dixon: 'we can no longer talk of film representing, or mimicking, reality, because we can no longer assume that there is a single, coherent reality waiting out there to be filmed' (Aitken and Dixon 2006: 326). In addition, media scholars have shown how different TV and film genres create their own 'reality-effect' (Black 2002; Clark and Doel 2005). In other words, it seems more justified to talk about a complex of multiple imaginations and realities, than about two separate worlds.

However, this problem can be easily overcome by re-interpreting Caughey's 'world of imagination' and 'real world' as two *emic* concepts, as part of how people try to categorize their own everyday life. Because imaginations and realities are interwoven, people feel the need to unravel them. Thus, places of the imagination

should not be interpreted as physical points of reference to an existing, factual opposition between ‘imagination’ and ‘reality’, but as locations where the symbolic difference between these two concepts is being (re-)constructed by those involved, based on what is considered ‘factual’ evidence.

A second question about the concept ‘places of the imagination’ is its historical uniqueness. Nora puts his analysis explicitly in the context of Modernism, a period which he sees as characterized by the erosion of traditional social bonds and the resultant desire for a shared past. This leads to the question to what extent the concept ‘places of the imagination’ is also explicitly associated with Modernism. Just a glance into history seems sufficient to discount this question. Far before the Modern era, great journeys were undertaken to visit places associated with the world of the imagination. As described in the introduction, there is a longstanding tradition of literary tourism and legend tripping, but at the same time, one cannot deny the strong increase in scale and the popularization of such trips in the current age.

The concept ‘places of the imagination’ is thus not new, but it has a new face today, being inextricably associated with the current media culture. We live in an age where the world of the imagination is primarily a media world, where television and the cinema have developed into the main storytellers of the age. If one looks for the material signs of this world of imagination, one quickly arrives at the film sets and locations used in the production of popular films and TV series.

In this regard, is there some connection with Jean Baudrillard’s notion of ‘hyperreality’? As set out in his introduction, Baudrillard posits the thesis that (post) modern man finds himself in an artificial world of artistic simulation, in which reproductions of reality have replaced every notion of reality. To what extent does this notion of hyperreality relate to the concept of ‘places of the imagination’? Both concepts share the idea that reality and the imagination are somehow interwoven. In both approaches a great deal of attention is paid to the spatial dimension – Baudrillard’s analysis focuses at length on the architecture and spatial arrangement of places like Las Vegas and Disneyworld.

That said, the concept of ‘places of the imagination’ differs in two crucial respects. First of all, Baudrillard presumes – as does Nora – a historical singularity. He suggests that hyperreality is a typically contemporary phenomenon that arises out of postmodern society. In the approach presented in this book, I point to the historical continuity between nineteenth- and eighteenth-century forms of media tourism and present-day examples. Underlying this is the supposition that for a long time a sort of zone of tension has existed between imagination and reality, but that at this point in time, this zone has possibly come more to the fore.

After this, Baudrillard’s rhetoric veers off in the opposite direction – an inflation of hyperreality, through which contact with reality becomes completely lost. The approach set out in this book adopts a less pretentious position, by suggesting that there is a continuous and separate relationship between both concepts, through which neither is considered inferior, precisely because they both exist by the grace of the other.

Model

To resume, it is the proposition of this book that the phenomenon of media tourism derives its power and popularity from the symbolic contrast between imagination and reality. Imagination and reality are not interpreted as two static entities, but as cultural constructs, which have a relationship with each other that exemplifies the separation between them. This relationship can be interpreted as a circular process, through which experiencing a place (through the senses or through symbols) fulfills a key function. Seen from this process-driven perspective, it becomes clear that the concept of ‘places of the imagination’ not only involves the physical locations themselves but also the underlying process. It relates to how the imagination literally ‘takes place’.

Figure 2.1 provides a schematic rendering of this process. It shows how artists – authors, scriptwriters, film directors – are inspired by their knowledge and experience of existing physical places (phase 1). After that they construct, using their creative imagination, stories that are played out in a specific time and place. Creative transformation is at the core of this process: artists transform existing texts, ideas, memories, sensory experiences and thoughts into a cultural

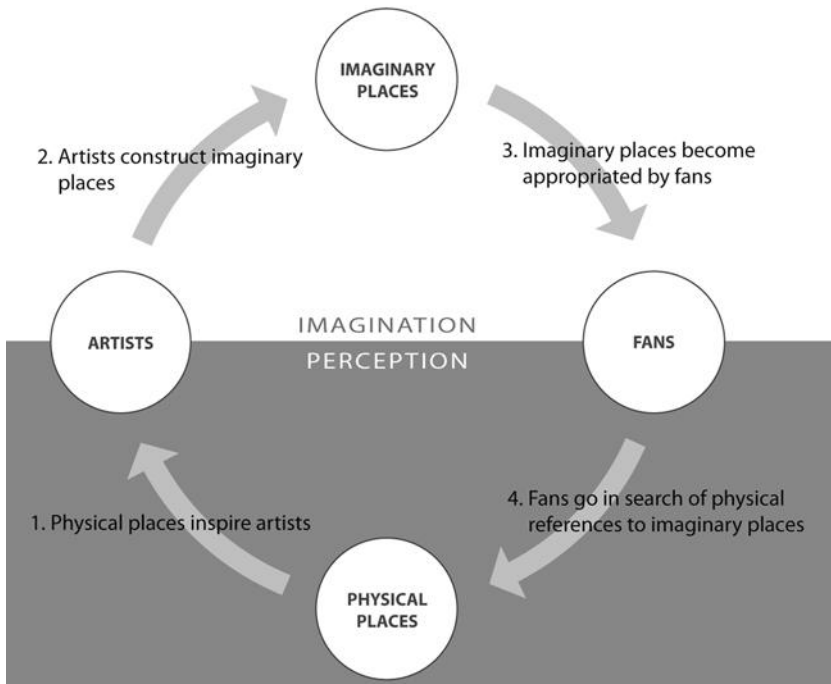


Figure 2.1 Media tourism as part of a circular process

Source: Model – Stijn Reijnders; Design – Ties Knapen.

Reijnders, Stijn. <i>Places of the Imagination : Media, Tourism, Culture</i>, Taylor & Francis Group, 2011. ProQuest Ebook Central, <http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/umainz/detail.action?docID=688661>.

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product – a film, television series or book – with its own narrative space (phase 2).

These imagined places become in their turn appropriated by fans or enthusiasts – be they readers, the television audience or visitors to the cinema (phase 3). Naturally, the images from a specific story, triggered in one's imagination do not have to match those originally conceived by the artist. The 'coding' and 'decoding' of a cultural product is a complex process, in which surface-noise, distortion and creative appropriation are more the rule than the exception (Hall 2000). In this sense, the cultural product provides the building blocks, with which the reader or viewer can design for themselves an image of the story being told and of the space in which the story is being played out. From this, a difference can also be found between written and audiovisual cultural products, which each in different ways, catch and stimulate the imagination.

Some of these fans subsequently decide to set off on the trail of physical references to this imaginary world, which they themselves have appropriated (phase 4). Where artists create an imaginary world on the basis of their experience of physical places, for fans the process is reversed: they use the imagination as a starting point and subsequently go and try to find in reality, material references to the world of their imagination. Of course the stories offer some guidance for these adventures. Many films, novels and television series make explicit reference to existing places or regions, mostly with the intention of lending a certain credibility to the product of the artist's imagination. However, as a rule, these references confine themselves to establishing the story generally in a certain city or region. It remains in most cases for the readers or viewers to fill in the geographical blanks. That is also precisely what makes identifying localities such an addictive activity: the fan is stimulated into giving meaning to what can only be read between the lines.

It is not only fans who are involved in ascribing locations in 'reality' to imagined places, but also local businesses and organizations. A striking example of this is the Morse pubs in Oxford. Various bars in Oxford present themselves as 'the' pub from Inspector Morse. They hang photographs of the filming on their walls, have posters and paintings of Morse and – in one particular case – even change the name of their establishment to capitalize on their association with Morse. This is about more than just a brand name. By giving themselves a place in the story, or, to put it better, by appropriating the story to their own environment, these pubs lend Morse a certain authenticity. Morse has become more and more regarded by many tourists as 'typically Oxford'. So now, by profiling themselves as 'the' Morse pub, these bars succeed in acquiring not only a reputation for themselves, but also a central position in 'the place myth' that is called Oxford.

The example of Morse, in particular, is played out at a local level. However, organizations are also involved in the localization of popular stories at a regional and even at a national level. For example, the tourism office of the British county of Kent recently arranged to have the region style itself as

‘Bond County’ because of its associations with James Bond and 007 author Ian Fleming.² Another example is the enthusiasm with which New Zealand’s office of tourism leapt onto the *Lord of the Rings* bandwagon. Localization and the appropriation of popular stories from the media have become big business.

Similar commercial practices can also lead to a process that could be described as the ‘sanctification’ of a location. Dean McCannell in his now classic study *The Tourist: A New Theory of the Leisure Class* (1976) describes how places can be transformed into tourist attractions in five phases:

1. *Naming*;
2. *Framing and elevation*;
3. *Enshrinement*;
4. *Mechanical reproduction*; and
5. *Social reproduction*.

If applied to the phenomenon of media tourism, there could well be question marks placed beside McCannell’s specific order of phases. The question arises of whether the phase called ‘social reproduction’ (the distribution of publicity about the location) should be the first rather than the last phase in the case of media tourism. Nevertheless, the concept of sanctification in a more general sense, still serves our purpose. I shall return to this theme in a later chapter.

To sum up, a new concept has been introduced in this chapter, elaborating on the existing concepts of *lieux de mémoire* and ‘hyperreality’. While Nora’s work indicates how authentic locations can stimulate the historical imagination, in this chapter the reverse process is described: how people actively go in search of material references to (re)confirm their notions of imagination and reality. *Lieux d’imagination* (places of the imagination) are defined as places of the imagination: material reference points which have a connection with certain stories. These places offer the opportunity, I would suggest, to construct a symbolic distinction between ‘imagination’ and ‘reality’. Places of the imagination enjoy a long tradition, which stretches back to before the advent of mass media, but they do currently form an intrinsic portion of our media culture.

The starting point was that imagination and reality have an inherent bond with each other. Imagination emanates from sensory experience – making a creative adaptation of what is known – and conversely the power of the imagination is necessary to assemble all the sensory stimulants into a coherent experience of ‘the’ reality. In order to visualize this line of reasoning, I have introduced a process-driven model consisting of four phases.

In the coming chapters, the idea of ‘places of the imagination’ and the accompanying model will be applied to, and conceptually refined by, three concrete examples. On the basis of a description of the concrete local developments

2 See: <http://www.visitkent.co.uk/explore/ebrochures-kent-james-bond.asp> [accessed: 1 December 2010].

surrounding the television detective tours in Amsterdam, Oxford and Ystad, the James Bond trip to numerous locations worldwide and the Dracula tours in Transylvania, I shall attempt to provide the foregoing theoretical explanation with flesh and blood.